

PREGNANT WITH A PROMISE

TEXT: Hebrews 10:35-39 (NKJV) *"Therefore do not cast away your confidence, which has great reward.36 For you have need of endurance, so that after you have done the will of God, you may receive the promise: 37 "For yet a little while, And He who is coming will come and will not tarry. 38 Now the just shall live by faith; But if anyone draws back, My soul has no pleasure in him." 39 But we are not of those who draw back to perdition, but of those who believe to the saving of the soul."*

INTRO: For some time now the Lord has been dealing with me concerning the subject we are going to delve into over the next several weeks; **"PREGNANT WITH A PROMISE."**

Because of the ever increasing information on the subject of leadership we hear more and more about dreams, visions, and goals. All these are necessary and good but if they are ever to become anything more than a good idea they must begin and end with a deposit of God in our spirits. These things should be a natural outflow of a God given promise.

A promise is a deposit of God in our spirit. Dreams, visions, and goals are man's way of attempting to strategically place him-self in a position to allow the promise to come to pass.

If the dreams, visions, and goals we are striving toward have not been conceived by God, we will wear our selves out reaching for what seems to be illusive and oftentimes unattainable.

No matter how much we study, plan, or work; if our dreams, visions, and goals are not a result of a deposit of God in our life in the form of a promise, the achievement of those things will leave us lusting for more.

A promise is more than a dream, vision or goal. Webster defines a promise in the following ways:

- A declaration that one will do or refrain from doing something specified **b** : a legally binding declaration that gives the person to whom it is made a right to expect or to claim the performance or forbearance of a specified act
- Reason to expect something; ground for expectation of success, improvement, or excellence
- Something that is promised

When it comes to fulfilling a God given destiny I believe all our plans must begin and end with a promise. ***"You have need of patience, so that after you have done the will of God..."*** We cannot very well do ***"the will of God"*** without knowing what His promise is.

Once we have received His promise we can then set direction that is governed by dreams, visions, and goals. These are vehicles that drive us toward the place where we can receive and accomplish the ***"promise of God!"***

The promise then, is the initiation of a process. Most of us do not like anything that requires a process; we want instant gratification, results and success.

The process of God requires reproduction. Reproduction, at any level, requires a process.

1) Charles R. Betticelli, Professor of Biology and Director of Mathematics at Newton College say's, *"Reproduction is the process by which human beings, animals, and plants create more of their own kind. The survival of all species of living things depends on reproduction. If any species stopped reproducing, it would disappear when its present members died off."*

Reproduction and pro-creation is, and always has been, the process through which God has moved His plans and programs forward. The promise is Gods, the process is ours! God deposits a dream in our life and then expects us to faithfully discharge the process of allowing the promise to come to pass.

When His promise comes to pass His agenda has been accomplished.

Remember, God is the originator of the promise; it is not really our promise it is His promise; we become pregnant with His promise. He is the daddy of our promises!

2) Charles Betticelli - *"The way a new organism develops after fertilization depends on chemical information in tiny structures called chromosomes. Each cell of the organism contains chromosomes."*

The process of the fertilization of the organism through chromosomes is where the DNA or genetic code of the organism begins to take shape. The DNA of the organism will eventually dictate:

- What the baby will look like, hair color, eye color, etc.;
- What the Baby's IQ will be
- What kind of personality the baby will have
- What kind of gifts and abilities the baby will possess

The promise we are pregnant with is not a thing, it is a part of the continuation of Gods program on earth. When God deposits a promise in our heart, that promise has a far greater destiny than our own encouragement or comfort.

The promise you are carrying is somehow connected to the promise I am carrying; the promises we are carrying are

somehow connected to the promise all other believers are pregnant with. The reason there is a connection is because all these promises have the same Father!

Likewise, when God builds a local church He brings people together whose promises are closely enough connected in their purpose to bring about something wildly exciting and successful. The fulfillment of such a thing is something we all want to be a part of.

Each one of us should be able to look at the vision statement of the church we attend and discover how the fulfillment of our promise would bring the local church closer to the overall accomplishment of its purpose. Once we make this discovery, we should find our place and begin the process of qualifying and serving in a ministry.

If we cannot figure out where we fit we are either not pregnant or we have picked the wrong doctor and hospital! Our promise must be able to fit into the vision of the house and if it does not, we are either sterile or in the wrong house.

3) Charles Betticelli - *"Human reproduction differs from reproduction in animals and plants because it involves more than just a biological (life) process. Among human beings, sex and reproduction involve love and other deep feelings."*

When the worlds were created the Bible say's Genesis 1:1-3 (KJV) ***"In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth. 2 And the earth was without form, and void; and darkness was upon the face of the deep. And the Spirit of God moved upon the face of the waters. 3 And God said, Let there be light: and there was light."***

In the immaculate conception of Jesus the Spirit and the Word came together! Matthew 1:18 (KJV) ***"Now the birth of Jesus Christ was as follows: After His mother Mary was betrothed to Joseph, before they came together, she was found with child of the Holy Spirit."***

On the part of God, the deposit of a promise in our life is not just a systematic approach to the accomplishment of His purposes in the earth. He doesn't need the help of anyone else to accomplish His purposes! He is a sovereign God! God could have accomplished all of His purposes without any of us!

God has chosen by an act of His own will to allow each of us to participate with His program on earth by allowing us to share the joy of carrying a part of His promise to full term.

The deposit of His promise within us is an act of love on His part. John 3:16 (KJV) ***“For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have everlasting life.”*** The willingness to carry out His promise is an act of love on our part." John 14:15 (NKJV) ***“If you love Me, keep My commandments.”***

4) Charles Betticelli - *"During the first two months of pregnancy the developing organism is called an embryo. Its development is programmed by the chemical information in the chromosomes from both the egg and the sperm. Within the first day after fertilization, the egg begins to divide. By the end of the first week, it has developed into a hollow ball of more than one hundred cells. During the second week, part of this ball becomes implanted (set) in the lining of the uterus.*

The promise that has been deposited within each of us is the God-part of our promise. From day one, the promise begins to take on our personality, gifts, and abilities. As each writer made His contribution to the Word of God, the personality, education, and abilities of the individual were never suffocated. We are oftentimes tempted to take the attitude that if God promised it that settles it. This philosophy removes all personal responsibility for the accomplishment of the promises of God. (Susan has said of some of the preachers I have mentored, "I can see you in him.")

Every pregnancy will present its own complications. Without proper pre-natal care the difficulties will certainly be more severe.

Almost all promises are conditional. The conditions often look like this:

- We carry it...
- We nurture it...
- We birth it...
- We grow it...

5) Charles Betticelli - *One of the first steps in development after implantation is the formation of a structure called the placenta. The placenta is a disk-shaped organ of tissues and blood vessels that is attached to the lining of the uterus. The umbilical cord connects the embryo and the placenta. The umbilical cord and placenta are a "life line" that carries oxygen and nourishment from the mother to the developing child. They also carry carbon dioxide and other waste back to the mother."*

No matter how determined a person is to give birth to a healthy promise; no matter how good the medical care has been; no matter how attentive the mother has been to excellent pre-natal care; if the lifeline of God is not connected to our promise, all our efforts will be in vain.

6) Charles Betticelli - *"The embryo begins to look like a human being after about five weeks. After about two months nearly all the internal organs have formed, and the growing organism is called a fetus. After about three months the fetus looks very much like a human baby."*

When a woman is pregnant, she is not carrying a fetus, she is carrying a baby. Because this society has been duped into believing, from conception to delivery, that which has been

conceived is a fetus, we are comfortable with aborting the fetus or doing something to miscarry it. If the abortion just involves a fetus then we are dealing with a thing, if it is a baby then we are dealing with a human being. This is why the abortionists never refer that which they are aborting as a baby.

Charles Betticelli tells us that for the first two months the "organism" is "called an embryo." After two months the "organism" is "called a fetus." Webster defines these three words in the following ways:

- *Organism: A complex structure of interdependent and subordinate elements whose relations and properties are largely determined by their function in the whole*
- *Embryo: A vertebrate (something having a spinal column) at any stage of development prior to birth or hatching; something as yet undeveloped; a beginning or undeveloped state of something*
- *Fetus: An unborn or un-hatched vertebrate especially after attaining the basic structural plan of its kind; specifically : a developing human from usually three months after conception to birth*

The argument about abortion seems to center around when life begins. Let's look at what the Word of God has to say about it. Psalm 139:13-18 (CEV) ***"You are the one who put me together inside my mother's body, 14 and I praise you because of the wonderful way you created me. Everything you do is marvelous! Of this I have no doubt. 15 Nothing about me is hidden from you! I was secretly woven together deep in the earth below, 16 but with your own eyes you saw my body being formed. Even before I was born, you had written in your book everything I would do. 17 Your thoughts are far beyond my understanding, much more than I could ever imagine. 18 I try to count your thoughts, but they outnumber the grains of sand on the beach. And when I awake, I will find you nearby."***

When we begin to realize it is really a baby rather than a fetus, the care for that child immediately raises to a different level of importance.

Even if it were legal, most mothers and fathers who abort a baby would not give birth to the child then take a butcher knife and kill it! (If you have ever participated in an abortion, whether you are a man or a lady, we can help you through Freedom in Jesus Ministries)

Why is abortion wrong?

- It terminates the plan of God for the life of a human being...
- It violates one of the Ten Commandments which has to do with the sanctity of life...
- The act of abortion makes it much easier to terminate the plan of God in other areas of our life as well...

Those who hate abortion often terminate Gods plan for others. We do this through gossip as well as a host of other ways and we often do it without a second thought!

Because most believers have never been taught that the promise they have is a part of God; and a part of them; they abort and miss-carry promise after promise. With every aborted or miscarried promise, come emotional and spiritual scars that oftentimes last a lifetime.

Each failed pregnancy causes us to become more and more sterile until we can no longer conceive a promise. We become barren. There are many reasons for barrenness:

- Fear (Israel)
- Doubt (Moses - had to have Aaron speak for him)
- Frustration (Abraham - Ishmael)

- Criticism (David's wife Michael)

7) Charles Betticelli - *"The mother can feel the fetus moving after about four months. Growth and development continue until about nine months after fertilization. The baby is then ready to be born."*

The baby is no more a reality when the mother begins to feel its movements that it was before. The pregnancy just seems more real! When the baby begins to move:

- Faith begins to build!
- Anticipation begins to arise!
- Expectation begins to manifest itself! (Paint its room - Buy clothing - Get serious about a name - Want to know whether it's a boy or girl - etc...)

Reproduction can take on many forms; reproducing furniture; reproducing clothing; reproducing buildings; reproducing human beings; or reproducing Gods plan in the earth.

From conception to delivery reproduction is all about the process. Oftentimes the lack of a vision is the reason for the stench of death in the church. Proverbs 29:18 (KJV) **"Where there is no vision, the people perish: but he that keepeth the law, happy is he."**

Another reason for infertility within the church is the lack of patience to carry the reproduction process through to its successful conclusion.

Many churches and Christians are dying for lack of a successful process of reproduction! A successful reproduction process requires that certain responsibilities be carried out.

Over the next few weeks I want to draw an analogy between all a woman goes through to have a good pregnancy and a healthy

baby and the things a believer must do to birth a vision or achieve a destiny.

The process a woman goes through to have a healthy baby is called pre-natal care. Pre-natal care has to do with personal responsibility. Every Christian who is pregnant with a promise must discharge personal responsibility with regard to the successful completion and implementation of a promise.

Let's look at the pre-natal process.

I. GETTING PREGNANT!

My research reveals that the time leading up to conception may very well be as important as the pregnancy itself. For potential parents the pre-conception period is pretty much defined as a minimum of thirty day's prior to conception.

Potential parents should do the following things during the pre-conception period:

- Visit a doctor for a physical checkup. Those of us who desire to become pregnant with a promise should visit Doctor Jesus to determine whether we are prepared to be pregnant with a promise. It is all about timing, His, not ours.
- Get to a healthy body weight. Being too thin or too overweight can cause problems for both the mother and the baby. Being too thin or too overweight can cause problems in a spiritual pregnancy as well.
- Stop taking all supplements unless prescribed by your doctor. Christians should eliminate all competing distractions. Hebrews 12:1-2 (KJV) *"Wherefore seeing we also are compassed about with so great a cloud of witnesses, let us lay aside every weight, and the sin which doth so easily beset us, and let us run with patience the race that is set before us, 2 Looking unto Jesus the author and finisher of our faith; who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross,*

despising the shame, and is set down at the right hand of the throne of God."

- Stop drinking alcohol and caffeine. Ephesians 5:15-18 (KJV) *"See then that ye walk circumspectly, not as fools, but as wise, 16 Redeeming the time, because the days are evil. 17 Wherefore be ye not unwise, but understanding what the will of the Lord is. 18 And be not drunk with wine, wherein is excess; but be filled with the Spirit;"*
- *Those who are anemic should resolve this medical problem before conception through diet and iron supplements prescribed by a doctor. Webster say's the word anemia is "A condition in which the blood is deficient in red blood cells, in hemoglobin, or in total volume. Llack of vitality."*
- According to Webster the condition of being anemic can be defined in the following ways: *"Relating to or affected with anemia. Lacking force, vitality, or spirit. Lacking interest or savor. Lacking in substance or quantity."* An anemic Christian will often times miscarry their promise. If they do not miscarry the promise they often times give birth to a diluted promise. Once the promise is birthed to an anemic person they sometimes develop it into a problematic promise.
- Use proper safety precautions around dangerous worksite agents, and household chemicals. 2 Corinthians 6:14-18 (KJV) **"Be ye not unequally yoked together**

with unbelievers: for what fellowship hath righteousness with unrighteousness? and what communion hath light with darkness? 15 And what concord hath Christ with Belial? or what part hath he that believeth with an infidel? 16 And what agreement hath the temple of God with idols? for ye are the temple of the living God; as God hath said, I will dwell in them, and walk in them; and I will be their God, and they shall be my people. 17 Wherefore come out from among them, and be ye separate, saith the Lord, and touch not the unclean thing; and I will receive you, 18 And will be a Father unto you, and ye shall be my sons and daughters, saith the Lord Almighty."

- No more lounging in hot tubs and saunas. God's command to Adam was to work and God's command to all of us is to work! John 9:4 (NKJV) *"I must work the works of Him who sent Me while it is day; the night is coming when no one can work."* Proverbs 6:6-11 (CEV) *"You lazy people can learn by watching an anthill. 7 Ants don't have leaders, 8 but they store up food during harvest season. 9 How long will you lie there doing nothing at all? When are you going to get up and stop sleeping? 10 Sleep a little. Doze a little. Fold your hands and twiddle your thumbs. 11 Suddenly, everything is gone, as though it had been taken by an armed robber."*
- Establish a healthy exercise routine. Exercise is essential to good health. 1 Timothy 4:8-9 (NKJV) *"For bodily exercise profits a little, but godliness is profitable for all things, having promise of the life that now is and of that which is to come. 9 This is a faithful saying and worthy of all acceptance."* We need a spiritual workout routine every day! (I jog around the block about two dozen times a day) (I lift weights)

The process of conception - Charles Betticelli - *"The process of reproduction begins when the male sperm fertilizes the female egg. The fertilized egg develops into a new member of the species."*

To become pregnant with a promise we must first be exposed to the presence of the Father! Some people are never going to be exposed to the presence of God long enough to conceive a promise.

If we want to become pregnant with His promise we must spend time hanging around in His presence.

II. EATING THE RIGHT DIET!

A person who is pregnant should eat a well-balanced diet that includes a wide variety of healthy foods from all the basic food groups. (Eating for two)

A person who is pregnant with a promise should nourish themselves in the following ways:

- Read the Word...
- Be a faithful attendee of a church that gives a steady diet of the Word...
- Attend a small group for discipleship purposes...
- Allow a well grounded person permission to speak encouragement and correction into our life...

Be aware that there are some foods that a pregnant person should completely avoid.

If we are pregnant with a promise we should serve faithfully in areas that will not put our promise at risk. When our service threatens our promise our service is obviously misplaced. Galatians 6:1 (NKJV) ***"Brethren, if a man is overtaken in any trespass, you who are spiritual restore such a one in a spirit of gentleness, considering yourself lest you also be tempted."***

Pregnant people should always keep well hydrated primarily by drinking water. Drinking water properly hydrates the human body as well as furnishes a vehicle to move all kinds of wastes and toxins from the body; this is true for both mother and baby.

One of the most dangerous and devastating things a pregnant person can do is become dehydrated. At any point during pregnancy dehydration places the child and its mother at risk.

In the Bible, water almost always represents the Word of God! Ephesians 5:22-30 (NKJV) *"Wives, submit to your own husbands, as to the Lord.²³ For the husband is head of the wife, as also Christ is head of the church; and He is the Savior of the body.²⁴ Therefore, just as the church is subject to Christ, so let the wives be to their own husbands in everything.²⁵ Husbands, love your wives, just as Christ also loved the church and gave Himself for her,²⁶ that He might sanctify and cleanse her with the washing of water by the word,²⁷ that He might present her to Himself a glorious church, not having spot or wrinkle or any such thing, but that she should be holy and without blemish.²⁸ So husbands ought to love their own wives as their own bodies; he who loves his wife loves himself.²⁹ For no one ever hated his own flesh, but nourishes and cherishes it, just as the Lord does the church.³⁰ For we are members of His body, of His flesh and of His bones."*

Ezekiel 36:25-28 (NKJV) *"Then I will sprinkle clean water on you, and you shall be clean; I will cleanse you from all your filthiness and from all your idols.²⁶ "I will give you a new heart and put a new spirit within you; I will take the heart of stone out of your flesh and give you a heart of flesh.²⁷ "I will put My Spirit within you and cause you to walk in My statutes, and you will keep My judgments and do them.²⁸ "Then you shall dwell in the land that I gave to your fathers; you shall be My people, and I will be your God."*

Isaiah 1:16-20 (NKJV) *"Wash yourselves, make yourselves clean; Put away the evil of your doings from before My eyes.*

Cease to do evil, 17 Learn to do good; Seek justice, Rebuke the oppressor; Defend the fatherless, Plead for the widow. 18 "Come now, and let us reason together," Says the LORD, "Though your sins are like scarlet, They shall be as white as snow; Though they are red like crimson, They shall be as wool. 19 If you are willing and obedient, You shall eat the good of the land; 20 But if you refuse and rebel, You shall be devoured by the sword; for the mouth of the Lord has spoken it."

Listen to what Jesus had to say about this water while dialoguing with the woman at the well; John 4:13-14 (NKJV)

*"Jesus answered and said to her, **"Whoever drinks of this water will thirst again, 14 "but whoever drinks of the water that I shall give him will never thirst. But the water that I shall give him will become in him a fountain of water springing up into everlasting life."***

III. TALKING TO THE BABY!

Most mothers and fathers talk to their baby during the nine months of pregnancy. Some mothers and fathers sing; hum; whistle; etc.

I don't suppose anyone knows for sure how much a baby can understand while it is in its mother's womb but talking to the baby accomplishes the following things:

- Permits the mother and father to get into the habit of communicating with the child before it is born...
- Allows the mother and father the opportunity of developing the habit of speaking positive things over their child prior to its birth...
- Changes the philosophy of the mother and father from thinking in terms of a pregnancy to the fact that this is a baby...
- Causes the pregnancy to come alive with excitement of what can and will be...
- Builds anticipation concerning the birth date and beyond...

- Causes the infant to recognize certain efforts of communication immediately following its birth... (Britt & Bailey)

Talking to your promise provides the following benefits for the pregnant believer:

- Permits us the opportunity to learn to communicate with our promise before it becomes a reality... Hebrews 11:1-2 (KJV) *"Now faith is the substance of things hoped for, the evidence of things not seen. 2 For by it the elders obtained a good report."* Hebrews 11:1-2 (CEV) *"Faith makes us sure of what we hope for and gives us proof of what we cannot see. 2 It was their faith that made our ancestors pleasing to God."*
- Allows us to develop the habit of speaking positive things over our promise before it is born... Romans 10:17 (KJV) *"So then faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the word of God."* We should speak the Word over our promise!
- Changes the attitude of the pregnant believer, from the promise being a thing, to being a baby - This does not allow for miscarriages or abortions...
- Allows the pregnancy to come alive with anticipation... Proverbs 18:20-21 (NKJV) *"A man's stomach shall be satisfied from the fruit of his mouth, From the produce of his lips he shall be filled. 21 Death and life are in the power of the tongue, And those who love it will eat its fruit."* Proverbs 18:20-21 (CEV) *"Make your words good—you will be glad you did. 21 Words can bring death or life! Talk too much, and you will eat everything you say."* We should develop the habit of speaking only positive things over our promise - Many children suffer from low self esteem because their parents have verbally abused them - What are we saying to and about our promise - If our promise follows our words will it be handicapped by underachievement, or will it be replete with hope and possibility?

- Builds anticipation of the birth date and beyond...
- Speaking and communicating to the promise causes us to be able to encourage ourselves about the viability of the promise... When David was living in Ziklag he went out to battle against an enemy and when he returned the city had been burned and all of the wives, children, and animals of the people had been taken captive. David went from being the hero to being the target of vicious activity! (Being a pastor is more precarious than being a football coach - With a coach, one bad season and you are out - With a pastor, one bad decision is all it takes) Look at what he does; 1 Samuel 30:6 (KJV) ***"And David was greatly distressed; for the people spake of stoning him, because the soul of all the people was grieved, every man for his sons and for his daughters: but David encouraged himself in the LORD his God."*** He was told by God to ***"pursue"*** the enemy for he would without doubt, ***"recover all."*** David knew how to encourage himself in the Lord, this was a lesson he learned while standing before Saul to volunteer for the fight against Goliath! Paul said, Acts 26:1-3 (NKJV) ***"Then Agrippa said to Paul, "You are permitted to speak for yourself." So Paul stretched out his hand and answered for himself:2 "I think myself happy, King Agrippa, because today I shall answer for myself before you concerning all the things of which I am accused by the Jews,3 "especially because you are expert in all customs and questions which have to do with the Jews. Therefore I beg you to hear me patiently."***
- Allows the promise to recognize certain efforts of communication immediately following its arrival... (A mother or fathers voice) (Britt & Bailey)

In writing to the Ephesians Paul addresses another important snapshot of how to fulfill the pre-natal responsibility of communicating with our promise. Ephesians 5:18-20 (KJV)

"And be not drunk with wine, wherein is excess; but be filled with the Spirit; 19 Speaking to yourselves in psalms and hymns and spiritual songs, singing and making melody in your heart to the Lord."

I want to define these three words for you:

- Psalms... Psalmos - (Saul-moss) - Striking or twanging the chords of a musical instrument while singing the Scriptural lyrics of a song.
- Hymns... Hymnos - (Hume-naws) - Lyrics that may not totally be words of Scripture but have been inspired by God. These words often are the first-fruits of the accomplishments of God, heroes, or conquerors. These always take the form of sacred songs. Some would say that the only songs we sing should be about God. However we have for years sang songs about the accomplishments of the saints. Most of these appear in what we call the great hymns of the church! Hymns are humanly inspired lyrics in song. (Illustration - Psalm 150:1-6 (NKJV) Praise the LORD! ***"Praise God in His sanctuary***(That is us! That can be this church when we are gathered together in this place); ***Praise Him in His mighty firmament*** (Expanse of His mighty; might; strength; material; physical; personal; social; and political power)! ***2 Praise Him for His mighty acts; Praise Him according to His excellent greatness! 3 Praise Him with the sound of the trumpet; Praise Him with the lute and harp! 4 Praise Him with the timbrel and dance; Praise Him with stringed instruments and flutes! 5 Praise Him with loud cymbals; Praise Him with clashing cymbals! 6 Let everything that has breath praise the LORD. Praise the LORD!"***
- Spiritual Songs...Spiritual - Pneumatikos - (P-nue-mot-ee-koss) - These are songs that relate to the human spirit, or rational soul. Spiritual songs are songs to God or about God. This song comes from the part of the person that is in closest communication with God, which is the

spirit of the person. This kind of song serves as the instrument or organ of God to ascribe praise and worship to God. The spirit of a person is that part of him that is higher than man but inferior to God. These songs can also take on the form of spontaneous rhythmic lyrics that are breathed into man's spirit by the breath of God and can be sung in tongues or with the understanding. 1 Corinthians 14:15 (KJV) ***"I will pray with the spirit, and I will pray with the understanding also: I will sing with the spirit, and I will sing with the understanding also."*** Spiritual songs can be songs that you make up as you go! This is a deep and reverent place of worship! This kind of worship is acceptable in private or corporate worship. (My own xperience)

**I give you the glory
I give You the honor
I give You the praise O Lord
For You are worthy
You are Holy
You are magnificent O Lord, O Lord!**

**You came and lived upon the earth
And paid the awful cost
You forgave me of all my sins
When you died upon the cross**

**You ascended to the Father and
You pray for all of us
You sent us Your Holy Spirit
And He is glorious**

**Now we're awaiting Your returning
Just as You have said
And with anticipation we are looking
for what is just ahead**

- Some people are so hung up on the style of worship that they have never been where I am talking about... It is time for us to go there!

Who is singing for?

- Singing is for those who desire to express praise and gratitude to God through Psalms, hymns and spiritual songs...
- Singing is for those who need a breakthrough... Paul and Silas - Acts 16:23-26 (KJV) ***"And when they had laid many stripes upon them, they cast them into prison, charging the jailor to keep them safely: 24 Who, having received such a charge, thrust them into the inner prison, and made their feet fast in the stocks. 25 And at midnight Paul and Silas prayed, and sang praises unto God: and the prisoners heard them. 26 And suddenly there was a great earthquake, so that the foundations of the prison were shaken: and immediately all the doors were opened, and every one's bands were loosed."***
- Singing is for those who are dry and thirsty... Numbers 21:17 (NKJV) ***"Then Israel sang this song: "Spring up, O well! All of you sing to it." The word "well" means pit or slime-pit. The word "sing" is "anah" - (haw-naw) - and means to answer, respond, testify, speak, or shout. It's time for someone who needs a breakthrough to quit wallowing in the slime-pit of despair and start singing to the thing! Answer it! Respond to it! Testify to it! Speak to it! Shout to it! Respond with a song of praise and God will turn your slime-pit into an artesian well! Psalm 30:4-5 (NKJV) "Sing praise to the LORD, You saints of His, And give thanks at the remembrance of His holy name. 5 For His anger is but for a moment, His favor is for life; Weeping may endure for a night, But joy comes in the morning." In Numbers 21 four things happen: (1) God gives instruction; Vs. 16, **"gather the people together..."** – There is unity and power in corporate gatherings. This is precisely why we are instructed to come together as a corporate church. Hebrews 10:23-25***

(NKJV) *"Let us hold fast the confession of our hope without wavering, for He who promised is faithful.²⁴ And let us consider one another in order to stir up love and good works,²⁵ not forsaking the assembling of ourselves together, as is the manner of some, but exhorting one another, and so much the more as you see the Day approaching."* There is not only a synergy in corporate gathering but there is tremendous power in corporate worship which is probably why the enemy fights this area of the church like he does. (2) God makes a promise; Vs. 16 *"I will give them water..."* Water represents the Word and means life. (3) The people fulfill their responsibility; Vs. 17, *"Then Israel sang this song, spring up, O well."* We have a responsibility to sing despite the circumstances! (4) God made good on His promise by giving them water! He is a covenant keeping God! He is a God that cannot lie! The lesson we should learn from this? (1) In times of pressure, anxiety, or depression, do not allow the enemy to isolate us but join together with other believers! (2) Gather with God's people, especially a praising people. (3) Regardless of your personal station in life, join in audible praise; sing to your well; the Living God! (4) Let your song be one of thanksgiving for the past, present, and future blessings of the Lord!

- Singing is for those who do not yet have their victory in their hand, but want to sacrifice praise unto God by faith!

XXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXX
 XXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXX10-13

(NKJV) *"Thus says the LORD: 'Again there shall be heard in this place—of which you say, "It is desolate, without man and without beast"—in the cities of Judah, in the streets of Jerusalem that are desolate, without man and without inhabitant and without beast,¹¹ 'the voice of joy and the voice of gladness, the voice of the bridegroom and the voice of the bride, the voice of those who will say: "Praise the LORD of hosts,*

For the LORD is good, For His mercy endures forever”— and of those who will bring the sacrifice of praise into the house of the LORD. For I will cause the captives of the land to return as at the first,’ says the LORD. 12 “Thus says the LORD of hosts: ‘In this place which is desolate, without man and without beast, and in all its cities, there shall again be a dwelling place of shepherds causing their flocks to lie down.13 ‘In the cities of the mountains, in the cities of the lowland, in the cities of the South, in the land of Benjamin, in the places around Jerusalem, and in the cities of Judah, the flocks shall again pass under the hands of him who counts them,’ says the LORD.” Isaiah 30:29 (NKJV)
"You shall have a song As in the night when a holy festival is kept, And gladness of heart as when one goes with a flute, To come into the mountain of the LORD, To the Mighty One of Israel."

- Singing is for those who are barren... Isaiah 54:1-4 (NKJV) *"Sing, O barren, You who have not borne! Break forth into singing, and cry aloud, You who have not labored with child! For more are the children of the desolate Than the children of the married woman,"* says the LORD. 2 *"Enlarge the place of your tent, And let them stretch out the curtains of your dwellings; Do not spare; Lengthen your cords, And strengthen your stakes. 3 For you shall expand to the right and to the left, And your descendants will inherit the nations, And make the desolate cities inhabited. 4 "Do not fear, for you will not be ashamed; Neither be disgraced, for you will not be put to shame; For you will forget the shame of your youth, And will not remember the reproach of your widowhood anymore."*
- Singing is for those who desire to celebrate a victory... Look at the song of Moses - Exodus 15:1-19 (NKJV)
 Then Moses and the children of Israel sang this song to the LORD, and spoke, saying: *"I will sing to the LORD, For He has triumphed gloriously! The horse and its*

rider He has thrown into the sea! 2 The LORD is my strength and song, And He has become my salvation; He is my God, and I will praise Him; My father's God, and I will exalt Him. 3 The LORD is a man of war; The LORD is His name. 4 Pharaoh's chariots and his army He has cast into the sea; His chosen captains also are drowned in the Red Sea. 5 The depths have covered them; They sank to the bottom like a stone. 6 "Your right hand, O LORD, has become glorious in power; Your right hand, O LORD, has dashed the enemy in pieces. 7 And in the greatness of Your excellence You have overthrown those who rose against You; You sent forth Your wrath; It consumed them like stubble. 8 And with the blast of Your nostrils The waters were gathered together; The floods stood upright like a heap; The depths congealed in the heart of the sea. 9 The enemy said, 'I will pursue, I will overtake, I will divide the spoil; My desire shall be satisfied on them. I will draw my sword, My hand shall destroy them.' 10 You blew with Your wind, The sea covered them; They sank like lead in the mighty waters. 11 "Who is like You, O LORD, among the gods? Who is like You, glorious in holiness, Fearful in praises, doing wonders? 12 You stretched out Your right hand; The earth swallowed them. 13 You in Your mercy have led forth The people whom You have redeemed; You have guided them in Your strength To Your holy habitation. 14 "The people will hear and be afraid; Sorrow will take hold of the inhabitants of Philistia. 15 Then the chiefs of Edom will be dismayed; The mighty men of Moab, Trembling will take hold of them; All the inhabitants of Canaan will melt away. 16 Fear and dread will fall on them; By the greatness of Your arm They will be as still as a stone, Till Your people pass over, O LORD, Till the people pass over Whom You have purchased. 17 You will bring them in and plant them In the mountain of Your inheritance, In the place, O LORD, which You have made For Your own dwelling, The sanctuary, O LORD, which Your hands

have established. 18 "The LORD shall reign forever and ever." 19 For the horses of Pharaoh went with his chariots and his horsemen into the sea, and the LORD brought back the waters of the sea upon them. But the children of Israel went on dry land in the midst of the sea."

The bottom line is this; if we are barren, we should sing; if we want to be pregnant, we should sing; if we want to have children, we should sing; if we want to raise a promise, we should sing!

Finally:

- We should sing, hum, and whistle to our promise...
- We should build relationships with people to whom we can articulate the particulars of our promise...
- We should build relationships with those who have enough faith to believe in our promise...

IV. THE WAITING PERIOD!

Every woman knows that when she discovers she is pregnant she is facing a nine month waiting period! Nine months! Why nine months? Because in the Divine order of God, that's how long it takes to develop a healthy baby!

Giving birth to a baby is a process; a process requires patience because it demands a waiting period. The process of pregnancy is described by Charles Betticelli in the following way: *"During the first two months of pregnancy the developing organism is called an embryo. Its development is programmed by the chemical information in the chromosomes from both the egg and the sperm. Within the first day after fertilization, the egg begins to divide. By the end of the first week, it has developed into a hollow ball of more than one hundred cells. During the second week, part of this ball becomes implanted (set) in the lining of the uterus... The embryo begins to look like a human being after about five weeks. After about two months nearly all the internal organs have formed, and the growing organism is*

called a fetus. After about three months the fetus looks very much like a human baby... The mother can feel the fetus moving after about four months. Growth and development continue until about nine months after fertilization. The baby is then ready to be born."

According to Charles Betticelli the pregnancy and its progress can be tracked from twenty four hours to nine months after fertilization and *"the baby is then ready to be born."* Not one moment before and not one moment later!

Everyone knows that a premature baby presents a whole list of complications for the baby, the parents, and the doctor!

We also know that if a woman is allowed to continue with a pregnancy beyond her due date, the overdue pregnancy will present equally difficult complications.

When some Christians become pregnant with a promise, they begin to focus all their energies on convincing the doctor to induce labor early or perform an early cesarean section. Over-anxiousness and lack of patience often cause complications that the pregnant person is not ready for.

Let us consider the high cost of over-anxiousness:

- Moses and Aaron... Numbers 20:1-5 (NKJV) ***"Then the children of Israel, the whole congregation, came into the Wilderness of Zin in the first month, and the people stayed in Kadesh; and Miriam died there and was buried there.² Now there was no water for the congregation; so they gathered together against Moses and Aaron.³ And the people contended with Moses and spoke, saying: "If only we had died when our brethren died before the LORD!⁴ "Why have you brought up the assembly of the LORD into this wilderness, that we and our animals should die here?⁵ "And why have you made us come up out of Egypt, to bring us to this evil place? It is not a place of grain or figs or vines or pomegranates; nor is there any water to drink."*** Moses

is told to gather the people together and take his rod to the meeting, but this time rather than striking the rock, he is to speak to it! (A rock followed them, ***"and that rock was Christ"***) Notice what he does. Numbers 20:10-11 (NKJV) ***"And Moses and Aaron gathered the assembly together before the rock; and he said to them, 'Hear now, you rebels! Must we bring water for you out of this rock?' 11 Then Moses lifted his hand and struck the rock twice with his rod; and water came out abundantly, and the congregation and their animals drank."*** Look at what Moses over-anxiousness cost him. Numbers 20:12 (NKJV) ***"Then the LORD spoke to Moses and Aaron, 'Because you did not believe Me, to hallow Me in the eyes of the children of Israel, therefore you shall not bring this assembly into the land which I have given them.'" Why such stringent punishment for such a seemingly insignificant infraction? First of all, over-anxiousness is a sin and the Holiness of God always demands a penalty for sin. Secondly, the rock in the wilderness represented Jesus, and Moses had already smitten the rock once at the instruction of God. The first striking of the rock was a type of the crucifixion of Christ. Once the rock was smitten it should never have been struck again, because once Christ died he can then be spoken to as a High Priest.***

- Naaman... Naaman was a high ranking official in the military forces of the King of Syria, but he was a leper. Naaman's wife had a servant who was a little Hebrew girl and she told her master that there was a prophet in Samaria by the name of Elisha who could cure Naaman of his leprosy. Naaman heeds her advice and attempts to seek Elisha out. Elisha refuses to meet with Naaman personally but sends him instruction to dip seven times in the river Jordan. Notice the response of Naaman. 2 Kings 5:11-12 (NKJV) ***"But Naaman became furious, and went away and said, 'Indeed, I said to myself, 'He will surely come out to me, and stand and call on the***

name of the LORD his God, and wave his hand over the place, and heal the leprosy.'12 "Are not the Abanah and the Pharpar, the rivers of Damascus, better than all the waters of Israel? Could I not wash in them and be clean?" So he turned and went away in a rage."

Because of his over-anxiousness, he almost missed his miracle.

Over-anxiousness often prevents us from realizing the finality of our promises. The old song say's *"Don't give up on the brink of a miracle."* I can't help but wonder how many times I have stopped just short of a tremendous victory?

A pregnancy is not about our comfort it is about delivering a healthy baby! James 1:2-4 (KJV) ***"My brethren, count it all joy when ye fall into divers temptations; 3 Knowing this, that the trying of your faith worketh patience. 4 But let patience have her perfect work, that ye may be perfect and entire, wanting nothing."***

Patience here is referred to as ***"her"***. The reason patience is referred to in this way is because it is a virtue that has the power to give birth to a promise.

We should guard against:

- Losing our nerve to follow through with our pregnancy patiently...
- Losing our will to fight off all enemies of the pregnancy...
- Losing our nerve to endure the pain of childbirth...

In business the foundation of success is location, location, location! The building of a successful corporation is leadership, leadership, leadership! The key to birthing a promise is patience, patience, patience!

Good things come to those who wait! We must learn to patiently wait on the Lord! Isaiah 40:29-31 (CEV) ***"The LORD gives strength to those who are weary. 30 Even young people***

get tired, then stumble and fall. 31 But those who trust the LORD will find new strength. They will be strong like eagles soaring upward on wings; they will walk and run without getting tired." (Children of Israel - 11 day's journey - 40 year trip) (Abraham - Sarah - Son Isaac)

We cannot rush our promise or destiny; we must accept it and be willing to wait on it. God will do it, but He will do it in His own sweet time!

V. THE PAIN OF THE LABOR ROOM!

Every woman who has ever given birth to a baby is very much aware of the pain connected to a place called the labor room.

The following things happen in the labor room:

- Contractions announce the approaching birth...
- The water breaks...
- The baby begins to travel down the birth canal...
- The mother must aid in the process by pushing...
- The pain is so intense it seems to be unbearable...

The believer who is pregnant with a promise undergoes a process that is strikingly similar to that of a baby being born.

Once the promise has been deposited into our lives there is a period of euphoria as we begin to prepare for its arrival; we spend much of our time imagining what life will be like when the promise arrives. This is a good exercise which tends to build faith.

The things most of us do not want to include in our euphoric plans are the waiting period and the painful process of the labor room. We often live as if we ignore it long enough the process can somehow be averted.

Once the promise matures to its birthing date it ceases to provide a great deal of comfort and can turn extremely painful. This is where some people fail in the process, preferring a late term abortion to the discomfort of the birthing process.

The contractions begin by giving us some discomfort but often end with being drenched with perspiration and screaming to the top of our lungs. The most frequently asked question at this point is *"If God is in this, how is it possible for Him to allow it to hurt so much?"*

Many years ago I had a Deacon whose favorite phrase was *"no pain, no gain!"* Earlier in this series we spoke about the baby (promise) beginning to move at about the four month time frame. When the baby (promise) begins to move it makes its presence known in a way that is undeniable. As the movement progresses the baby (promise) begins to punch and kick its mother. This is all still in the "cute" stage.

In the labor room the movement of the baby (promise) is marked by very painful contractions. This is the point at which most Christians consider a late term abortion reasoning that if this were of God it could not possibly hurt this much.

The level of pain or comfort is not a good indicator of our positioning in the will of God. If we are going to give birth to a promise contractions are inevitable. Listen to what Paul says to his young son in the faith, Timothy. 2 Timothy 3:10-12 (NKJV) ***"But you have carefully followed my doctrine, manner of life, purpose, faith, longsuffering, love, perseverance, 11 persecutions, afflictions, which happened to me at Antioch, at Iconium, at Lystra—what persecutions I endured. And out of them all the Lord delivered me. 12 Yes, and all who desire to live godly in Christ Jesus will suffer persecution."*** This was not the greatest recruiting tool available.

The water has either been broken prior to the arrival in the labor room or it will be broken in the labor room. Once this occurs it marks a point of no retreat. The baby (promise) must be born or it will perish. (When Cortes landed in Vera Cruz he burned the ships behind him - The only remaining option was the Mexican interior)

At conversion, if I died to sin and self, the following things will be impossible:

- You can't hurt a dead man...
- You can't discourage a dead man...
- You can't insult a dead man...
- You can't change the path of a dead man...

The breaking of the water destroys the insulated, protected environment in which the baby (promise) has lived for the last nine months. It is at this point that everything is going to change for the baby (promise) and its parents. Now there will either be a birth announcement or an obituary. All paths of retreat have been severed! It is now a choice; go full steam ahead; or abort the baby (promise)! Luke 9:62 (NKJV) ***"No one, having put his hand to the plow, and looking back, is fit for the kingdom of God."***

The baby (promise) begins to travel down the birth canal. Each movement is replete with its own pain and complications. As painful as it is, this process is necessary if the baby (promise) is to be born.

James 1:2-4 (KJV) ***"My brethren, count it all joy when ye fall into divers temptations;(various trials) 3 Knowing this, that the trying (testing) of your faith worketh patience. 4 But let patience have her perfect work, that ye may be perfect and entire, wanting nothing."***

The mother must aid in the birthing process by pushing! Most of us just want to lie around and let God do all the work. We assume that if it is His will He will bring it to pass whether we invest any effort or not. To refuse to do our part in the birthing process is to allow the discomfort of the previous nine months to be for naught, without our participation, the promise will not come to pass. We must make the choice; birth; or abort!

It is not that God cannot do it without us, He has chosen by an act of His own will to use us to bring it to pass.

Just before the baby (promise) is born the pain seems to be unbearable. Remember: "...after you have done the will of God, you may receive the promise: 37 "For yet a little while, And He who is coming will come and will not tarry. 38 Now the just shall live by faith; But if anyone draws back, My soul has no pleasure in him." 39 But we are not of those who draw back to perdition, but of those who believe to the saving of the soul." Hebrews 10:36-39

If we can endure the pain of the labor room, the celebration of the delivery room is not far away. Matthew 10:22 (NKJV) **"And you will be hated by all for My name's sake. But he who endures to the end will be saved."** Hebrews 12:6-11 (NKJV) **"For whom the LORD loves He chastens, And scourges every son whom He receives."** 7 If you endure chastening, God deals with you as with sons; for what son is there whom a father does not chasten?8 But if you are without chastening, of which all have become partakers, then you are illegitimate and not sons.9 Furthermore, we have had human fathers who corrected us, and we paid them respect. Shall we not much more readily be in subjection to the Father of spirits and live? 10 For they indeed for a few days chastened us as seemed best to them, but He for our profit, that we may be partakers of His holiness. 11 Now no chastening seems to be joyful for the present, but painful; nevertheless, afterward it yields the peaceable fruit of righteousness to those who have been trained by it."2 Timothy 2:1-15 (NKJV) **"You therefore, my son, be strong in the grace that is in Christ Jesus.**2 **And the things that you have heard from me among many witnesses, commit these to faithful men who will be able to teach others also.**3 **You therefore must endure hardship as a good soldier of Jesus Christ.**4 **No one engaged in warfare entangles himself with the affairs of this life, that he may please him who enlisted him as a soldier.**5 **And also if anyone competes in athletics, he is not crowned unless he competes according to the rules.**6 **The hard-working farmer must be first to partake of the crops.**7 **Consider what I say, and may the Lord give you understanding in all things.**8 **Remember that Jesus Christ, of the seed of David, was raised from the dead according to my**

gospel, 9 for which I suffer trouble as an evildoer, even to the point of chains; but the word of God is not chained. 10 Therefore I endure all things for the sake of the elect, that they also may obtain the salvation which is in Christ Jesus with eternal glory. 11 This is a faithful saying: 11 For if we died with Him, We shall also live with Him. 12 If we endure, We shall also reign with Him. If we deny Him, He also will deny us. 13 If we are faithless, He remains faithful; He cannot deny Himself. 14 Remind them of these things, charging them before the Lord not to strive about words to no profit, to the ruin of the hearers. 15 Be diligent to present yourself approved to God, a worker who does not need to be ashamed, rightly dividing the word of truth. James 5:10-11 (NKJV) *"My brethren, take the prophets, who spoke in the name of the Lord, as an example of suffering and patience. 11 Indeed we count them blessed who endure. You have heard of the perseverance of Job and seen the end intended by the Lord—that the Lord is very compassionate and merciful."*

Look at the patriarch Job... Job 42:10 (NKJV) ***"And the LORD turned the captivity of Job, when he prayed for his friends: also the LORD gave Job twice as much as he had before."***

JOB'S WEALTH BEFORE THE TRIAL!

7,000 sheep... @\$20.00 each...\$140,000.00

3,000 camels...@\$100.00 each...\$300,000.00

1,000 oxen... @\$325.00 each...\$325,000.00

500 asses... @\$50.00 each \$25,000.00

TOTAL ESTIMATED VALUE: \$790,000.00

JOB'S WEALTH AFTER THE TRIAL!

14,000 sheep... @\$20.00 each...\$280,000.00

6,000 camels... @\$100.00 each...\$600,000.00

2,000 oxen... @\$325.00 each....\$650,000.00

1000 asses... @\$50.00 each...\$50,000.00

TOTAL ESTIMATED VALUE: \$1,580,000.00

Job 42:16 (NKJV) ***"After this lived Job an hundred and forty years, and saw his sons, and his sons' sons, even four generations."***

Job was 70 years old when his trial began, and he lived to be 210 years old! God gave him twice as much life following his head-on collision with the devil, than he had before his problems! Think about that, God doubled his life span!

The pain of the labor room is designed to flow into the celebration of the delivery room!

VI. THE CELEBRATION OF THE DELIVERY ROOM!

Over the past several weeks we have talked extensively about becoming pregnant; eating the right diet; talking to the baby (promise); the waiting period; and the pain of the labor room.

Today I want us to focus in on the celebration of the delivery room! Notice the process, the pregnancy begins with the exhilaration of discovery and S-L-O-W-L-Y inches its way toward the pain of the labor room. (Have you ever faced a situation that began with excitement and suddenly it takes an ugly turn and no matter how hard you tried you could not turn it around?) (I did not start it to raining)

Never forget, the pain of the labor room is always followed by the celebration of the delivery room!

In the delivery room:

- The baby transitions from one environment to another...

- The doctor has a window of opportunity to follow the right procedures...
- The mother has a responsibility, to P-U-S-H...
- The father has the responsibility of M-O-R-A-L S-U-P-P-O-R-T...
- The Doctor has a responsibility to do everything humanly, ethically, and legally possible to make sure the baby arrives in a timely manner... (He uses his hands, forceps, etc. It is not a pretty scene)
- The parent's transition from expectancy to responsibility...
- The baby demands immediate and constant care... It MUST eat! It MUST sleep! It MUST use the restroom! It MUST be burped!
- The discomfort of the pregnancy and the pain of the labor room are washed away in a sea of amnesia as the baby is laid in its mother's bosom...
- Ugly babies look pretty in the delivery room... The reason ugly babies look pretty in the delivery room is because the parents see them for who they are and what they will be! (There's an old country song that says *"all the girls get prettier at closing time."* No joke, you are drunk!) In the delivery room the parents are intoxicated by the arrival of their child.

In the delivery room where promises are born:

- The promise transitions from one environment to another... At this point the promise goes from being one with the mother to being a work in progress.
- The promise goes from being protected by the body of the mother to being protected by the effort and attention of the parents...
- The promise goes from being sustained from the input and output of the umbilical cord to being fed by its mother...
- The work of God is evident in the delivery room... The birthing of the promise demands divine intervention. We cannot get to the delivery room without divine

intervention and we should not attempt to deliver a promise without it! Philippians 4:13 (NKJV) ***"I can do all things through Christ who strengthens me."*** 2 Samuel 22:40 (NKJV) ***"For You have armed me with strength for the battle; You have subdued under me those who rose against me."*** Isaiah 28:5-6 (NKJV) ***"In that day the LORD of hosts will be For a crown of glory and a diadem of beauty To the remnant of His people, 6 For a spirit of justice to him who sits in judgment, And for strength to those who turn back the battle at the gate."*** Daniel 11:32 (NKJV) ***"Those who do wickedly against the covenant he shall corrupt with flattery; but the people who know their God shall be strong, and carry out great exploits."*** Ephesians 3:16 ***"That He would grant you, according to the riches of His glory, to be strengthened with might through His Spirit in the inner man,"***

- The believer transitions from expectancy to responsibility...
- The promise demands immediate attention... It can't feed itself! It can't clothe itself! It can't change itself! It needs to be rocked, talked to, played with, etc...
- The birthing of a new promise is not just a cute occasion; it is the dawn of a new era of responsibility... The promise will use the restroom on you; spit up on you; have a temper tantrum (I have wished to be the parent of some children who have thrown a temper tantrum in public); and at the most inconvenient times embarrass you. (Jason and Bro. Harris)
- For the believer, the discomfort of the pregnancy and the pain of the labor room are forgotten in the delivery room...
- The arrival of the promise places into proper perspective the intensity of the discomfort and the value of the promise... 2 Corinthians 4:1, 16-18 (NKJV)

"Therefore, since we have this ministry, as we have received mercy, we do not lose heart. 16 Therefore we do not lose heart. Even though our outward man is perishing, yet the inward man is being renewed day by day.17 For our light affliction, which is but for a moment, is working for us a far more exceeding and eternal weight of glory,18 while we do not look at the things which are seen, but at the things which are not seen. For the things which are seen are temporary, but the things which are not seen are eternal."

- Ugly promises look pretty in the delivery room... What does not seem significant to one believer is the pinnacle of success to another believer! 1 Corinthians 12:26-27 (NKJV) *"And if one member suffers, all the members suffer with it; or if one member is honored, all the members rejoice with it.27 Now you are the body of Christ, and members individually."*

After a nine month process of celebration, difficulty, pain, and discomfort; one whimper from the lips of the baby and all is forgotten.

There is apprehension until the umbilical cord is cut; the baby has been swatted on its backside; the screaming from the child has begun; the fingers and toes have been counted; it is at this point that the celebration begins!

Once that baby has been laid in the bosom of its mother the tears of joy begin to flow; the word filters out to the waiting room; the phone calls begin; the high fives echo across the room; there is now reason for celebration.

When our promise is birthed we soon forget the process that brought it to pass because it is really not about the process it is about delivering on a healthy promise.

Hebrews 10:35-39 (NKJV) *"Therefore do not cast away your confidence, which has great reward.³⁶ For you have need of endurance, so that after you have done the will of God, you may receive the promise: ³⁷ "For yet a little while, And He who is coming will come and will not tarry. ³⁸ Now the just shall live by faith; But if anyone draws back, My soul has no pleasure in him." ³⁹ But we are not of those who draw back to perdition, but of those who believe to the saving of the soul."*

THE END!